SERMON AUDIT

The New Heaven and the New Earth, Part 1 (Revelation 21:1–3) John MacArthur

Pastor John MacArthur · Grace Community Church · 2026-04-16 · 01:08:03

Preaching text: · *Gospel translation:* ESV

Video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wirnL4nli1Y

Scorecard

FIDELITY TO JESUS'S TEACHINGS (RED LETTERS)

Mixed — faithful on some, selective on others

Four flagged items. Jesus's direct quotations (John 14:1–3, Matt 5:8, Luke 23:43) are rendered faithfully, but the sermon's central pastoral thrust — that disengagement from earth is the mark of spiritual maturity — sits in tension with Jesus's Lord's Prayer ('on earth as it is in heaven') and Matthew 25's embodied this-world criterion for inheriting the kingdom. Matthew 25:31–46 is absent from a sermon about the eternal state.

IDENTIFIABLE BIASES / HARMFUL RHETORIC

Largely absent

No anti-Muslim, anti-LGBTQ, misogynistic, anti-Jewish, or Christian-nationalist content detected. A mild jeremiad about 'Western culture' and 'instant gratification' is present but generic. One low-level dismissal of creation-care and one throwaway anti-evolution remark; neither rises to harmful rhetoric.

FACTUAL CLAIMS & EVIDENCE CHECK

Multiple astronomy errors

The 5-minute astronomy illustration contains several distance figures wrong by orders of magnitude (Alpha Centauri stated as '20 billion years away'; Betelgeuse distance ~280× actual; lunar distance off by ~27,000 mi). Separately, 'your blood is 90% water' overstates whole-blood water content. The astronomical error set does not undermine the theological point (the universe is vast) but is delivered with authoritative precision it does not have.

WHOLE-BIBLE ENGAGEMENT

Selective — one canonical strand preached as the canon

On heaven, earth, and the body, the Bible holds several voices in tension: heaven-escape (2 Cor 5; Phil 3:20), earth-renewal (Rom 8:19–23; Isa 65 read whole; Rev 21:3 itself — God comes DOWN), and this-world kingdom (Matt 6:10; Matt 25). MacArthur preaches strand 1 robustly, strand 2 selectively, and strand 3 barely at all.

Summary

MacArthur preaches a dispensationalist exposition of Revelation 21:1–3, arguing that the present universe will be "unccreated" and replaced by a literal new heaven and new earth containing the New Jerusalem as its capital. The sermon's pastoral thesis is that Christians are insufficiently "heavenly-minded" and that the comfort of Western culture has made the church worldly. Along the way MacArthur dismisses creation-care ("save the planet people are really wasting their time"), reads Ecclesiastes 7:1 as "better to die than to be born," characterizes the world's cities as uniformly unholy, offers a 5-minute astronomy illustration with several factually wrong distance figures, and takes a brief swipe at evolution. Unlike much of MacArthur's public corpus, this particular sermon is largely free of politically charged rhetoric — no identifiable anti-Muslim, anti-LGBTQ, misogynistic, anti-Jewish, or Christian-nationalist content is present. The audit's concerns are primarily Axis 1 (tension between heaven-escape framing and Jesus's this-world kingdom teaching, plus notable absence of Matt 25 and the Lord's Prayer) and Axis 3 (multiple astronomy figures off by orders of magnitude, plus an overstated "blood is 90% water" claim).

Timeline

Each marker = a flagged finding. Click to jump to the finding; hover for the title. Color indicates severity.

00:00:00 01:08:03

Findings (5)

MODERATE AXIS 1 (absent from a sermon on heaven and the final state)

HEADLINE

Matthew 25 absent from a sermon on the eternal state

Why flagged: The sermon's pastoral diagnosis is that Christians are 'laying up treasure on earth' rather than heaven. Jesus's own instructions on how, concretely, to lay up treasure in heaven — Matt 6:19–21, Luke 12:33, and most extensively Matt 25 — describe embodied care for the hungry, thirsty, stranger, naked, sick, and imprisoned. A heaven-focused sermon that exhorts congregants toward heavenly-mindedness without engaging Jesus's direct answer omits the passage most directly on topic.

PASTOR

[absent] — In a 67-minute sermon on the new heaven and new earth, Jesus's own most extended teaching on what he will do when the nations are gathered before his throne (Matt 25:31–46) is never referenced.

JESUS

Matt 25:31–46

When the Son of Man comes in his glory… before him will be gathered all the nations… 'I was hungry and you gave me food, I was thirsty and you gave me drink, I was a stranger and you welcomed me, I was naked and you clothed me, I was sick and you visited me, I was in prison and you came to me.'… 'Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me.'

Matt 6:19–21

Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth… but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven… For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.

Luke 12:33

Sell your possessions, and give to the needy. Provide yourselves with moneybags that do not grow old, with

a treasure in the heavens that does not fail.

MODERATE | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:29:30 | HEADLINE

'Save the planet people are really wasting their time' — creation-care dismissed

Why flagged: Jesus's red-letter prayer is that God's will be done 'on earth as it is in heaven' — not that earth be abandoned. His parables assume faithful stewardship of the master's property in his absence; the servant who writes off the master's holdings is the one condemned. Framing ecological concern as a waste of time ('take that burden off your back') while assuring the congregation that God's plan requires the earth's destruction short-circuits the biblical stewardship vocation. The caveat ('not saying you should wantingly pollute') softens but does not restore the imperative.

PASTOR

The goals of all those who want to save the earth, the save the planet people are really wasting their time because this one will be replaced by an eternal new heaven and new earth… the earth is not headed for an ecological crisis. I want to take that burden off your back. The earth is not headed for an ecological crisis. It is not headed for an ecological holocaust. It is headed for an escatological holocaust.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Matt 6:10 (Lord's Prayer)

Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

Matt 25:14–30 (Parable of the Talents — the wicked servant is the one who buries the master's property assuming the master's disposition is destructive)

You wicked and slothful servant!… You ought to have invested my money with the bankers, and at my coming I should have received what was my own with interest.

Luke 16:10–12

One who is faithful in a very little is also faithful in much, and one who is dishonest in a very little is also dishonest in much… if you have not been faithful in that which is another's, who will give you what is your own?

Gen 2:15 — the vocation Jesus's Scripture opens with

The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it.

LOW | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:04:45

Ecclesiastes 7:1 inverted — 'better to die than to be born'

Why flagged: Ecclesiastes 7:1 says 'a good name is better than precious ointment, and the day of death than the day of birth' — in Qoheleth's ironic wisdom register, not a generalized preference for death. Generalizing it into 'it is better to die than to be born' as a Christian truism runs against Jesus's red-letter ministry, which is conspicuously pro-life-now: he raises the dead, weeps at death (John 11:35), values even sparrows' lives, and calls himself the giver of abundant life. Paul's 'to depart and be with Christ is far better' (cited in the sermon) explicitly pairs 'far better' for Paul with 'more necessary for you' for the church (Phil 1:24) — Paul chooses to stay. The sermon uses only the half of the tension that fits its thesis.

PASTOR

The preacher in Ecclesiastes chapter 7 and verse one was right. He didn't intend it this way. But he was right when he said the day of one's death is better than the day of one's birth... though he may have approached it cynically, what he said was indeed truth. It is better to die than to be born.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

John 10:10

I came that they may have life and have it abundantly.

John 11:25–26, 35 (at Lazarus's tomb — Jesus weeps before raising him)

I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in me, though he die, yet shall he live... Jesus wept.

Mark 5:41 (raising Jairus's daughter)

Taking her by the hand he said to her, 'Talitha cumi,' which means, 'Little girl, I say to you, arise.'

Luke 12:6–7

Are not five sparrows sold for two pennies? And not one of them is forgotten before God. Why, even the hairs of your head are all numbered. Fear not; you are of more value than many sparrows.

LOW | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:43:00

Cities as uniformly wicked — against Jesus's urban lament

Why flagged: Jesus's posture toward cities is lament and mission, not categorical dismissal. He weeps over Jerusalem rather than writing it off and commits to preaching 'in the other towns as well.' Categorical city-derogation ('we don't know anything about a holy city') sits in tension with the Bible's own ending image — a city descending from God to dwell with humanity, precisely the text being preached. Low-severity tension, but directional.

PASTOR

Certainly, Los Angeles wouldn't qualify the world's cities. In fact, just the opposite of being holy of all of human society, the most unholy is in the cities, isn't it? The world's cities are pockets of wickedness, pockets of unholy living and unholy thinking... From New York to Tokyo, from Los Angeles to Moscow, from Rio to Paris, we don't know anything about a holy city.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Luke 19:41

And when he drew near and saw the city, he wept over it.

Matt 23:37

O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the city that kills the prophets and stones those who are sent to it! How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!

Luke 4:43

I must preach the good news of the kingdom of God to the other towns as well; for I was sent for this purpose.

Isa 56:6–7 — cited by Jesus in Matt 21:13, Mark 11:17 when cleansing the Temple

For my house shall be called a house of prayer for all peoples.

LOW | AXIS 2 | ▶ 00:35:30

Throwaway anti-evolution aside

Why flagged: Low-severity flag: the rhetorical dismissal conflates 'abiogenesis / habitability' (the uniqueness-of-Earth question) with 'biological evolution' (the descent-with-modification question). These are distinct scientific questions; dismissing the second by appeal to the first is a category error. Not a harm-driving rhetorical move on its own, but representative of the sermon's pattern of asserting scientific-sounding claims without evidentiary grounding.

PASTOR

The earth, did you know, is the only place in the known universe where there's water enough to sustain man, plants, and animals? Tell me that's evolution. Can't be.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Mark 12:30 (Greatest Commandment — includes 'mind')

And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind and with all your strength.

Matt 10:16

Be wise as serpents and innocent as doves.

Whole-Bible Engagement (3)

For each major framing in the sermon, the pastor's claim is placed side-by-side with **what Jesus said in the Gospels** and **what the wider Bible says** (OT + NT non-Gospel). Surfaces cherry-picking, omitted counter-voices, and places where the canon itself contains tension the pastor did not acknowledge.

MODERATE | AXIS 4 | ▶ 00:29:30 | HEADLINE

Earth as 'disposable' — the escape strand preached as the whole canon

TOPIC: WHAT GOD INTENDS TO DO WITH THE MATERIAL CREATION

Why flagged: The pastor presents one canonical strand (earth-replacement) as the Bible's single voice while omitting the renewal strand (Rom 8; Col 1:20; Isa 65 read whole) and underreading his own preaching text (Rev 21:3 God-comes-down). The ethical conclusion drawn — that creation care is 'wasting their time' — is derived from the selective reading.

CANONICAL ANALYSIS

The canon holds two images of creation's end in unresolved tension: destruction/replacement (2 Pet 3:10–13; aspects of Rev 20–21) and renewal/reconciliation (Rom 8:19–23; Col 1:20; Isa 65 read whole; Rev 21:3 itself). The Greek of 2 Pet 3:10 is textually contested — the oldest manuscripts read 'will be found' (heurethēsetai), not 'will be burned up.' The sermon's own preaching text (Rev 21:3) envisions God coming DOWN to dwell with humanity on a renewed earth — an incarnational direction, not an evacuation. Isaiah 65:17 (cited by MacArthur) keeps going: vs. 21–22 describe people building houses and planting vineyards — continuity, not just replacement. Rev 11:18 promises judgment on 'the destroyers of the earth' — a verse that makes little sense if the earth is meant to be destroyed anyway. MacArthur preaches the 'disposable' strand as if it were the canon's single voice and draws the ethical conclusion (creation care is pointless) from it. Even within a conservative evangelical hermeneutic (N.T. Wright, Richard Bauckham, Douglas Moo, Jonathan Moo) this is a minority reading. The practical upshot — 'I want to take that burden off your back' — discourages the congregation from engaging a canonical vocation on the grounds of an uncertain eschatological mechanism.

PASTOR

The earth we live on is temporary disposable. We're not to preserve it. That's pointless... It is disposable. It is unraveling. It is declining. It is winding down... The goals of all those who want to save the earth, the save the planet people are really wasting their time.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS (GOSPELS)

Matt 6:10 (Lord's Prayer)

Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

Matt 5:5 (Beatitudes)

Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth.

Matt 25:14–30 (the master returns and expects stewardship of what was entrusted)

You wicked and slothful servant!... Take the talent from him and give it to him who has the ten talents.

Gen 1:31; Gen 2:15 — the Scripture Jesus inherited

And God saw everything that he had made, and behold, it was very good... The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it.

WIDER BIBLE (OT & NT NON-GOSPEL)

Rom 8:19–23 (Paul)

For the creation waits with eager longing for the revealing of the sons of God... that the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to corruption and obtain the freedom of the glory of the children of God. For we know that the whole creation has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth until now.

Rev 21:3 (the sermon's own text)

Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God.

Rev 11:18

The time for the dead to be judged, and for rewarding your servants, the prophets and saints, and those who fear your name, both small and great, and for destroying the destroyers of the earth.

Isa 65:17–25 (read whole — the 'new heaven and new earth' passage MacArthur cites verse 17 from)

They shall build houses and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit... The wolf and the lamb shall graze together; the lion shall eat straw like the ox, and dust shall be the serpent's food. They shall not hurt or destroy in all my holy mountain, says the Lord.

Ps 24:1

The earth is the Lord's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein.

Col 1:20 (Paul)

> Through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.

MODERATE | AXIS 4 | ▶ 00:02:00

Heavenly-minded / earthly-minded binary — underreads 'on earth as it is in heaven'

TOPIC: WHERE CHRISTIANS SHOULD DIRECT THEIR ATTENTION AND EFFORT

Why flagged: Selecting two Pauline passages (Col 3; Phil 3) as the canonical framing while omitting Matt 25, Jas 1:27, 1 John 3:17, and Mic 6:8 produces a truncated spirituality. The canonical counter-voice — that heaven-focus is tested by embodied love of concrete neighbors — is not engaged.

CANONICAL ANALYSIS

MacArthur's framing ('heavenly-minded' vs. 'earthly-minded' as a zero-sum) draws heavily on Col 3:1–2 and Phil 3:20 — both legitimate Pauline voices. The selectivity lies in treating those two passages as decisive while omitting the texts where heaven-focus is tested specifically by this-world behavior: Matt 25 (which the sermon never cites), Jas 1:27 (religion tested by orphans and widows), 1 John 3:17 (love for God tested by material generosity to a brother in need), Mic 6:8 (what God actually requires). Jesus's own framing in the Lord's Prayer is not 'get me out of earth' but 'bring your kingdom here.' His high-priestly prayer explicitly disclaims the take-them-out-of-the-world request. The resulting pastoral exhortation is lopsided: it defines spiritual maturity primarily as inner longing for heaven, never defining it in terms of the actual Jesus-criteria (hungry fed, stranger welcomed, sick visited, widow cared for). The sermon could have affirmed heaven-hope AND this-world embodiment — the canon does. It affirms only the first.

PASTOR

We are living in a society of instant gratification, material comfort, and endless indulgences. And the church has become worldly. Nothing demonstrates that, I don't think, any more graphically than the lack of interest in heaven. Most Christians are to some degree or another more interested in laying up treasure on earth than in heaven... We waste our lives. They hinder the power of the church and they are consumed with fading things.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS (GOSPELS)

Matt 6:9–10 (Lord's Prayer)

Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

Luke 17:20–21

The kingdom of God is not coming in ways that can be observed, nor will they say, 'Look, here it is!' or 'There!' for behold, the kingdom of God is in the midst of you.

Matt 25:31–46 (the criterion for inheriting the kingdom is embodied this-world care)

'I was hungry and you gave me food… I was a stranger and you welcomed me, I was naked and you clothed me…' 'Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me.'

John 17:15 (Jesus's high-priestly prayer)

I do not ask that you take them out of the world, but that you keep them from the evil one.

Deut 6:5 — cited by Jesus in Matt 22:37, Mark 12:30 as the great commandment

You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might.

WIDER BIBLE (OT & NT NON-GOSPEL)

Col 3:1–2 (cited by MacArthur)

Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth.

Phil 3:20 (cited by MacArthur)

But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ.

Jas 1:27 — the canonical balance

Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world.

Mic 6:8

He has told you, O man, what is good; and what does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?

1 John 3:17 — test of whether heaven-focus is real

But if anyone has the world's goods and sees his brother in need, yet closes his heart against him, how does God's love abide in him?

MODERATE | AXIS 4 | ▶ 00:53:00

New Jerusalem read only as destination, not as pattern for the church's life now

TOPIC: HOW REV 21 SHOULD SHAPE PRESENT CHRISTIAN PRACTICE

Why flagged: The pastor treats the New Jerusalem as destination only, not as pattern. Rev 21:24–26 and 22:2 (nations walking by its light, leaves for healing of the nations) are within the preaching text's immediate neighborhood but are not engaged. The result is a vision of heaven that does not require anything of the present church.

CANONICAL ANALYSIS

Rev 21–22 is a picture of the New Jerusalem drawing the nations into itself and producing healing for them. The dominant patristic, Augustinian, and much Protestant reading treats this city as both telos and pattern — a vision that forms the church's present common life and outward posture toward 'the nations' and 'the kings of the earth.' Paul's Eph 2 applies 'city / holy temple' language to the church's present existence. The sermon treats the New Jerusalem strictly as a future destination — a geographic endpoint 1,500 miles cubed that descends to the post-destruction universe. This is defensible as a dispensationalist reading, but it leaves the sermon with no practical payoff: the vision of Rev 21:3 ('God dwells with them') has no bearing on how this congregation should live differently on Monday, because the vision is reserved entirely for the post-destruction future. The wider canon reads Rev 21 and Matt 5:14 together: the city-that-comes-down shapes the city-on-a-hill. The sermon reads only the first.

PASTOR

I saw the new Jerusalem coming down and it's made ready as a bride adorned for her husband. It's time for the consummation… The capital city of eternity… home will be the new Jerusalem.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS (GOSPELS)

Matt 5:14 (Sermon on the Mount)

You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden.

John 13:34–35

A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. By this all people will know that you are my

disciples, if you have love for one another.

Matt 6:10 (Lord's Prayer)

Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

WIDER BIBLE (OT & NT NON-GOSPEL)

Rev 21:24–26 (the same passage MacArthur is preaching — later in the chapter)

By its light will the nations walk, and the kings of the earth will bring their glory into it… They will bring into it the glory and the honor of the nations.

Rev 22:2

The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.

Eph 2:19–22 (Paul's present-tense 'holy temple' / 'city' language for the church)

You are fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God… being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord.

Heb 13:14

For here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come.

Factual Claims & Evidence Check (4)

Empirical claims the pastor made during the sermon, with a verdict on whether independent evidence supports them. Verdict scale: Supported · Partially supported · Contested · Misleading · Unsupported · False. “Evidence the pastor cited” records whether any source was named in the sermon itself.

FALSE ▶ 00:19:00

“Alpha Centauri is '20 billion years away'; the North Star is '400 billion'; Betelgeuse is '880 quadrillion miles away...”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

Alpha Centauri is '20 billion years away'; the North Star is '400 billion'; Betelgeuse is '880 quadrillion miles away' with 'a 200 million mile diameter.'

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None. Delivered as precise astronomical fact in an illustration about heaven's distance.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

All three figures are significantly wrong relative to modern astronomical consensus. (1) Alpha Centauri: ~4.37 light-years, which is ~25.7 trillion miles; '20 billion years' is a category error (years, not miles) and even reading it charitably as '20 billion miles' is off by ~1,300×. (2) Polaris (North Star): ~433 light-years ≈ ~2.5 quadrillion miles, not 400 billion; off by roughly 6,000×. (3) Betelgeuse: distance ~500–550 light-years ≈ ~3.1 quadrillion miles, not 880 quadrillion — off by ~280×; and Betelgeuse's diameter is estimated at roughly 700 million miles (~1.2 billion km), not 200 million. The figures are presented with the rhetorical confidence of a fact-check-ready illustration; they do not survive one. The underlying theological point (the universe is vast) is unaffected, but delivering wrong figures with authority undermines pulpit credibility on verifiable claims.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- NASA Science — Alpha Centauri
- NASA — Polaris (The North Star)
- ESA/Hubble — Betelgeuse (size and distance)

FALSE ▶ 00:18:30

“The moon is 211,463 miles away; 'you could walk to it in 27 years if you could walk 24 miles a day.'”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

The moon is 211,463 miles away; 'you could walk to it in 27 years if you could walk 24 miles a day.'

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

The mean Earth–Moon distance is approximately 238,855 miles; perigee ~225,000 mi and apogee ~252,000 mi. 211,463 miles falls below even the closest recorded perigee and does not correspond to any standard NASA reference figure. The walking-time arithmetic is also internally inconsistent with the figure: 211,463 ÷ 24 ≈ 8,811 days ≈ 24.1 years, not 27. Minor error, low stakes, but delivered with specificity.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- NASA — Earth's Moon: Facts

PARTIALLY SUPPORTED / OVERSTATED ▶ 00:34:30

“'Your blood is 90% water; your flesh is 65% water.'”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

'Your blood is 90% water; your flesh is 65% water.'

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

Human blood plasma is approximately 92% water, but plasma makes up only ~55% of whole blood; the remainder (red and white cells, platelets) is cellular mass. Whole-blood water content is therefore closer to 50%, not 90%. The 90% figure applies to plasma specifically. 'Flesh is 65% water' is roughly defensible for overall adult body composition (~60% in men, ~55% in women) and skeletal-muscle tissue is ~75% water — the 65% figure sits inside the plausible range. The substantive point (humans and earth are water-dependent) is correct; the specific blood figure materially overstates whole-blood water content.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- USGS — The Water in You: Water and the Human Body
- NIH / StatPearls — Physiology, Blood Plasma

NEEDS VERIFICATION ▶ 00:15:30

"'Heaven is referred to 550 times or so in scripture. Heaven is referred to 54 times in the book of Revelation.'"

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

'Heaven is referred to 550 times or so in scripture. Heaven is referred to 54 times in the book of Revelation.'

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

These are lexical counts that depend on translation (ESV vs. KJV vs. NASB) and whether 'heavens' (plural) is included alongside 'heaven.' Broadly plausible — a KJV English concordance count for 'heaven' is in the 550–600 range, and 'heaven' appears dozens of times in Revelation — but verifying the exact 550 / 54 figures requires specifying translation and lemma rules. Low-stakes claim; noted for completeness rather than concern.

Tenets affirmed

- Direct Jesus quotations are rendered faithfully: 'Let not your heart be troubled' and 'I go to prepare a place for you' (John 14:1–3); 'Blessed are the pure in heart, for they shall see God' (Matt 5:8); 'Today you will be with me in paradise' (Luke 23:43) — all handled accurately in their Gospel context.
- Resurrection realism is affirmed explicitly against disembodied-soul spiritualism: 'We will be literally raised. We will be literally given resurrection bodies' — consistent with 1 Cor 15 and the creedal tradition.
- Eschatological hope is grounded in God's presence, not rewards or real estate: the sermon's climax is Rev 21:3 ('the dwelling place of God is with man') and the repeated refrain from Ps 73:25 ('Whom have I in heaven but thee?'), locating heaven's goodness in God himself.
- Verse-by-verse exposition from the actual biblical text, with Hebrew (shamayim) and Greek (ouranos, kainos vs. neos) lexical distinctions noted correctly.

Counter-signals

- Explicit disavowal of wanton pollution: 'I'm not saying that you should wantingly pollute the world and make life difficult.'
- No named political party, candidate, movement, or voting instruction.
- No flag, pledge, or civil-religion imagery; no 'America' framing at all.
- No attack on any identifiable religious, ethnic, gender, or sexual-minority group.
- Closes with a gospel invitation for 'anyone who hears this message that is not on the way to heaven' rather than a call to political or cultural action.
- Emphasizes God-centeredness ('We want to be there because God is there') over reward-centeredness.

Christian Nationalism marker rubric (Whitehead/Perry, Du Mez, Alberta)

MARKER	STATUS	NOTES
A. Conflation of national & Christian identity	None detected	No reference to America, any nation, or national inheritance.
B. Militaristic / warrior framing	None detected	No combat, armor-of-God, or masculine-warrior rhetoric.
C. Political opponents as spiritual enemies	None detected	
D. Dominionist rhetoric	None detected	The sermon's direction is disengagement from the world, the opposite of institutional capture.
E. Civil religion (flag, pledge)	None detected	
F. Jeremiad / 'Christianity under attack'	Low	'Western world… society of instant gratification, material comfort, and endless indulgences… the church has become worldly' — cultural critique rather than persecution claim; no targets named.
G. Ethno-cultural 'real American' undertones	None detected	

MARKER	STATUS	NOTES
H. Strongman / authoritarian affinity	None detected	

Other Axis-2 sub-rubrics

- **Anti-Muslim framing:** Not present in this sermon
- **Anti-LGBTQ framing:** Not present in this sermon
- **Misogynistic framing:** Not present in this sermon — Bride-of-Christ imagery is handled corporately (all the redeemed) rather than gendered-role prescriptively.
- **Anti-Jewish framing:** Low / contextual — Dispensationalist framework distinguishes Israel from the church and routes 'tribulation saints,' 'Old Testament saints,' etc. as separate categories. The parenthetical 'a Jew who wouldn't even say the name of God because of fearful reverence' is stated respectfully. No supersessionist triumphalism in this sermon.
- **Dismissal of creation-care:** Present — see Finding f1-1 and f4-1 — Not a standard named rubric, but the sermon's most identifiable rhetorical move with real-world consequences for how the congregation engages environmental questions.

Full transcript

Highlighted paragraphs contain flagged content (color = severity). Click any timestamp to jump to that moment on YouTube.

[00:00:00] I think throughout the history of the church, heaven has been a preoccupation of God's people. Many songs have focused on heaven because people through the years in the life of the church have been loosely tied to earth and so they have longed for heaven. I suppose even this time in the history of the world around the globe where Christians don't have it as comfortably as we do, there is still a great anticipation for heaven.

[00:00:30] Most Christians, I suppose, through the centuries could say with the psalmist in Psalm 73, "Whom have I in heaven but thee? And besides thee, I desire nothing on earth." That is the expression of the heart that longs for God. Much like Psalm 42 where the psalmist says, "As the deer pants after the waterbrook, so pants my soul after thee,

[00:01:00] oh God." The psalmist in that same psalm, Psalm 73 said, "Nearness to God is my good." He said, "God is my portion forever." Being preoccupied with the person of God, longing to be in the presence of God was on the heart of Christians. In fact, the pure in heart according to the words

[00:01:30] of Jesus in the biatitudes are promised that they will someday see God through the centuries. That desire to see God, to be in God's presence, to enjoy God forever. That desire that there is nothing in the world that can satisfy has been on the hearts of believers. But it's not so in this culture, not in this society in which we live, in the

> [00:02:00] western world. We are living in a society of instant gratification, material comfort, and endless indulgences. And the church has become worldly. Nothing demonstrates that, I don't think, any more graphically than the lack of interest in heaven. Most Christians are to some degree or another more interested in laying up treasure on earth than in heaven. They're more concerned with their investments and their retirement package → Heavenly-minded / earthly-minded binary — underreads 'on earth as it is in heaven'

> [00:02:30] and their own future on earth than they are with heaven. I suppose most Christians sacrifice the eternal blessing of glory on the altar of temporal gratification. We don't talk about heaven much. We don't sing about heaven much because we're really not that interested. The old song said, "Heaven on my mind." But that's not really true anymore → Heavenly-minded / earthly-minded binary — underreads 'on earth as it is in heaven'

[00:03:00] because believers do not have heaven on their mind. They waste their lives. They hinder the power of the church and they are consumed with fading things. We could address this issue of having lost a heavenly perspective from a number of passages. We could talk about Paul's words to the Philippians in which he reminds them and us that our citizenship is in heaven.

[00:03:30] Chapter 3 20. and that we are waiting for the one who will transform the body of our humble state into conformity with the body of his glory. Or we might even look at Colossians 3 where it says, "Set your affections on things above and not on things on the earth." Or we might even study 1 John 2:15-17 where it says, "Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world. For all that is in the world, the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life, is not of God, but is of the world, and the world passes away.

[00:04:00] We could even study the passage in James where James says friendship with the world is enmity with God. You see everything connected to our spiritual life and destiny is in heaven. Our father is there. Our savior is there. Our comforter is there. Our fellow believers are there. Our name is there. Our life is there. Our inheritance is there. Our home is there. Our citizenship is there. Our reward is

> [00:04:30] there. Our treasure is there. Everything that belongs to us is there. Consequently, Paul told the Romans that they should be rejoicing in hope. That the closer they are to heaven, the more joy they should experience. I don't know that we see that. I see even Christians close to heaven trying desperately to hold on to this life. But the preacher in Ecclesiastes chapter → Ecclesiastes 7:1 inverted — 'better to die than to be born'

> [00:05:00] 7 and verse one was right. He didn't intend it this way. But he was right when he said the day of one's death is better than the day of one's birth. And that is true for a Christian. And though he may have approached it cynically, what he said was indeed truth. It is better to die than to be born. Because to die for a believer is to enter into a better place than birth ushers us into. The Apostle Paul understood that when he → Ecclesiastes 7:1 inverted — 'better to die than to be born'

[00:05:30] said, "For to me to live is Christ and to die is gain. Therein he voiced his perspective." And the reason we should have a longing for heaven is because God is there. And whom have we in heaven but him? And whom do we desire on earth but him? He should be our supreme affection, our

[00:06:00] supreme love, our supreme desire. And if he's in heaven, then heaven should be the place we long to be. In first Kings chapter 8, eight times it says that God is in heaven. And if indeed he is the supreme object of our affection, if he is our great love, if we love the Lord our God in any proximity to loving him with all our heart, soul, mind, and strength, then we would long to be in heaven with him. And we would say with

[00:06:30] the psalmist, I desire nothing on earth but you. And whom have I in heaven but you? I want to be there because you're there. Not because my friends are there. Not because my family is there. Not because my relatives are there, but because you're there. This has a powerful effect on our lives to desire heaven. And frankly, we could wish that we lived in a less comfortable culture.

[00:07:00] We could even wish that we lived in a poor culture. We could wish that we lived in a persecuted culture so the world would not seem so good to us and heaven would seem so much better. In 1 John chapter 3, first two verses, John says, "See how great a love the father has bestowed on us that we should be called children of God and such we are. For this reason the world doesn't know us

[00:07:30] because it didn't know him. Beloved, now are we the children of God. And it has not appeared as yet what we shall be. We know that when he appears, we shall be like him because we shall see him just as he is. That's the attraction of heaven. We'll see him just as he is. No more veil, no more distance, no more mystery, the complete revelation of God. And then John says in verse three, he that hath this hope in him purifies himself.

[00:08:00] It purges your life to hope for heaven. John Bunan writing in that marvelous pilgrim's progress which demonstrates such genius in making the Christian life into a graphic illustration or allegory has a conversation between two pilgrims who are on their way to the celestial city which of course is heaven. One of the two pilgrims says to the other, "When do you find yourself

[00:08:30] in the most wholesome and most vigorous spiritual state?" to which the other pilgrim says, "When I think of the place to which I am going," Bunan understood that when he wrote that, he understood that heaven on your mind changes your life. The living in a joyous anticipation of the presence of God changes everything.

[00:09:00] Sadly, I suppose most Christians are more like the cynical Mark Twain, who when told about heaven, remarked flippantly, "You take heaven. I'd rather go to Bermuda." A true and vivid longing for heaven has many marvelous implications and many marvelous benefits.

[00:09:30] A true and vivid longing for heaven, for example, is an evidence of genuine salvation. Because when a person longs for heaven, you know they're longing for God. They're demonstrating love for the Lord. They're showing you where their heart is. And not only that, where you see a strong longing for heaven, there is incentive to the highest

[00:10:00] excellence of Christian character. Why? Because anyone who loves heaven and anyone who longs for heaven and anyone who seeks that which is above and anyone whose heart is in heaven is one who loves to commune with the living God. one who travels there in meditation, who travels there in devotion, who travels there in prayer, who travels there in study, and that's a purging fellowship.

[00:10:30] Furthermore, a true and vivid longing for heaven is the truest path to a life of joy. Because if you're really living in heaven and if all your anticipation is there and you recognize that that is the great desire of your heart, then you can endure absolutely anything in this life and never have your joy affected. What does it matter what happens here in view of heaven's glories? Furthermore, a true and vivid anticipation of heaven is the best

[00:11:00] preservative against sin. Because the more heavenly minded you are, the less likely you are to stoop to the degrading level of the world. The more you set your affections on things above, the less likely you are to follow fleshly impulses. Furthermore, true and vivid longing for heaven will maintain the vigor of your spiritual service.

[00:11:30] Those Christians who run slow, those Christians who work little, those Christians who make a minimal effort at serving God, demonstrate little regard for eternal

things. Many of them work very hard at earthly things and very little at eternal things. Why? Because they in their minds have

[00:12:00] designed that the the prize to be gained here is more worthy of their effort than the prize to be gained there. What a deception. You see, ferveny in service, diligence in service, faithfulness in service is related to anticipation of heavenly benefit.

[00:12:30] I ask myself that constantly. What is the heavenly benefit of my life? What will be the heavenly benefit of that endeavor? What does it matter for eternity? Furthermore, a true and vivid longing for heaven honors God above everything else. Because when your heart is in heaven, it's because he is there and he is the supreme one. The true devotion and longing for heaven also repays God's goodness. You say, in what sense? Well,

[00:13:00] when we set our affections on things above, in a sense, we have given back to God what he's given us because his heart is always set on us and certainly ours should be set on him. So when you want to find an evidence of genuine salvation in someone's life and when you want to find a motive or incentive to the highest excellence of Christian virtue and when you're looking for someone who has true joy, someone who can stand against temptation, someone who maintains the vigor and

[00:13:30] diligence of spiritual service, someone who honors God above everything else, and someone who wants to repay God for his goodness, you're going to find somebody whose heart is in heaven. the noblest of all Christians, the godliest of all saints, the most virtuous of all believers are going to be heavenly minded and they're going to live in the light of eternity. So when we talk about heaven in our study of the book of Revelation, having

[00:14:00] come to chapters 21 and 22, we're not just talking about pie in the sky. We're talking about something that has immense implications for how we live our lives. And frankly, we're talking about something that should bring great conviction. It does disturb me. I confess that every single seat in this church isn't filled and and uh people pressing against the doors on the outside. It should be enough to announce we're going

[00:14:30] to talk about heaven. That every believer would be here if he had to paddle his own boat. In some places in our world even today that would be the case where people have suffered much and where they love God much. And so as we come to the closing two chapters of the book of Revelation after all these months and even several years of study, we come now to the subject of

[00:15:00] heaven. And my prayer is that it will rekindle the fires in every heart. the fires of preoccupation with the land of glory which awaits us. Let's get some foundational data first. Okay. Heaven is referred to 550 times or so in scripture. Heaven is referred to

54 times in the book of Revelation. The Old Testament Hebrew word is samayim. It means the heights.

[00:15:30] The New Testament word is Uranus from which we get the planet Uranus. It means that which is elevated, that which is lifted up, that which is raised up. Heaven is the raised up place, the heights. Scripture simply delineates three heavens. In 2 Corinthians 12:2, it says Paul was taken up into the third heaven. That's the heaven where God dwells. That's the third heaven. The first

[00:16:00] heaven is the atmospheric heaven. That's the atmosphere around the earth. That's the air we breathe. The second heaven is the heaven of the heavenly bodies, the planets, the stars, the moons, and everything else. The last heaven, it's the heaven of God. It's the divine heaven, the abode of God and angels and saints. And people have asked throughout the centuries, where is it? Where is it?

[00:16:30] We believe it's a place because there are some people there who actually have bodies. Is that not true? Like Enoch who took a walk one day and walked right up to heaven. And the prophet Elijah who went to heaven in a chariot and the Lord Jesus Christ who's there in a glorified body. And there's going to be a lot more people there in their glorified bodies

[00:17:00] because Jesus said in John 14, he went to prepare a place for us. And someday he'll come and bring us there. And when he does bring us, according to First Thessalonians, our body is going to be transformed. We're going to get a new body to go into that heavenly place. It's a place. You say, "Isn't it just a sort of a spiritual consciousness?" No, it's a place. It's a place where the spiritual and the transcendent glorified bodies of the saints will dwell with the glorified

[00:17:30] Christ and the holy angels. Now, exactly where it is is not given. We just know one one detail. It's up. It's all we know. You say, "How do you know it's up?" Because that's what the Bible says. In Revelation for example chapter 4 verse one after these things John writes and behold a door standing open in heaven I looked and saw the door and the first

[00:18:00] voice which I heard like the sound of a trumpet speaking with me said come up here. So from where John was standing heaven was up. In 2 Corinthians 12:es 1 to4 Paul says he was caught up into the third heaven. It's up. Now I know the next question. How far up? Well, the moon is 211,463 miles. You could walk to it in 27 years if you could walk 24 miles a day. It's

[00:18:30] not that far. Now, if we could just crank up your speed a little bit to like 186,000 miles per second, you could get to the moon in a second and a half. which is

really the better way to go if you're going to take the trip. At that speed, you could reach Jupiter in 35 minutes and 11 seconds because it's only 367 million miles away. And if

[00:19:00] you could go 186,000 m per second, you could get to Saturn in 7 in in 1 hour and 11 seconds because it's only 790 million miles away. Now remember, you've got to go 186,000 m a second to get there in an hour and 11 seconds. But you see, when you've gotten to Saturn and you've gone beyond and you've even gotten to Pluto, which is into the billions of miles away, when you've arrived at the very extremity of what we know as our solar system, you haven't even gotten out of the front yard,

[00:19:30] you're still at the very, very beginning of heaven. Because Alpha Centuri, which is a star, is 20 billion years away. The North Star 400 billion. And then a star Balgeist 880 quadrillion

[00:20:00] miles away. And by the way, it's big. They have discovered it has a 200 million mile diameter. And you want to know something? When you get there, you're still in our galaxy. And there are billions of galaxies. And they say that our galaxy probably has a diameter of 100,000 light years. That's going at the rate of 186 miles a second for a year.

[00:20:30] And when you've gotten through our galaxy, there are billions more. So when we say up, it is up. You say, "Well, must take a long time to get there." Luke 23:43, Jesus said to the thief on the cross. In 100,000 years, you'll be with me in

[00:21:00] paradise. Is that what he said? Said what? Isn't that amazing? And the Apostle Paul said, "Absent from the body, present with the Lord." 2 Corinthians 5'8, far better to depart and be with Christ. Though in a sense, it's outside the created order as we know it. It's it's in a different dimension than time and space. And so it's a little facitious to

[00:21:30] assume that it's miles away. But you understand that the great heaven of God is way beyond the created world. And yet we can be there in a split second. In fact, when the rapture comes, it's going to happen in the twinkling of an eye. That doesn't mean a blink. That's different. Twinkling means the light, the time it takes for light to refract off your pupil.

[00:22:00] And what do we know about heaven? Well, only what the Bible says. Ezekiel tried, we give him credit, tried to explain it in chapter one. I'm not going to read it to you because it's you can read it yourself, but he talked about storms and he talked about fire flashing and jewels and metal and glowing metal and living creatures and bronze and spinning wheels inside of wheels and from verse four down through 28, he he

[00:22:30] gave his best effort at describing the indescribable. And Paul went there and came back in 2 Corinthians 12. And uh sad to say the Lord didn't let him tell about it

because he says he was not allowed to describe it. So Ezekiel is giving us a description that's very hard to comprehend. Shining, brilliant, blazing, glorious light and

[00:23:00] jewels. Paul doesn't even get to tell us what he saw. So the best look at it is here in John's Revelation. We're going to get the best glimpse of heaven anywhere in scripture here in chapter 21 verse one down through chapter 22 verse 5. This is a monumental text of scripture then because it describes for us our future home. Now remember Jesus said in John 14 that he was going to go away and prepare a place for us and this is the place he prepared for us. And we'll see how that

[00:23:30] fits together in a moment. Let's turn to chapter 21. And at least for tonight, we'll take a shot at the first three verses. And I saw a new heaven and a new earth. For the first heaven and the first earth, passed away, and there is no longer any sea. And I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, made ready as a bride adorned for her husband. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "Behold, the tabernacle of God is among men, and he shall dwell among them, and they

[00:24:00] shall be his people, and God himself shall be among them." Now, friends, that is enough uh for me to preach on for months. It is so glorious. But let me just give you three features that come out of these verses. First of all, the appearance or the vision of the new heaven and the new earth. Let's call it the appearance of the new heaven and the new earth. Verse one. And I saw a new heaven and a new earth. For the first heaven and the

[00:24:30] first earth passed away, and there is no longer any sea. Now remember, as this chapter opens, let me just give you a fast review. As this chapter opens in the chronology of end times, all the sinners of all the ages, demons and men, including Satan, the false prophet, the antichrist, and everybody else, are now in the eternal lake of fire. They are out of the presence of God and

[00:25:00] the saints and the holy angels forever. They have been dismissed into their own disconnected, isolated place of eternal punishment. They are gone from the presence of God, the saints and angels forever. Additionally, the whole universe as we know it, the entire universe, all the way out to endless space through all the billions and billions of light years, all of it has been destroyed.

[00:25:30] All of it has been reduced to energy. All the matter that makes up the entire universe has been reduced to energy. So the universe as we know it is gone. All the ungodly are gone. And God then takes the holy angels and the godly of all the ages and creates for them a new universe which is to be the eternal dwelling place of the redeemed

[00:26:00] and of the angels who worship God. This is what Ephesians 1:10 has in mind when it says the fullness of times has come. That is the summing up of all things, things in

the heavens and things upon the earth. Ephesians 1:10. This is it. This is the eternal state.

[00:26:30] This will exist forever and forever. Let's look at the verse. And I saw I have to stop at that phrase. That little phrase is a technical phrase. It's been used since chapter 19:1. Chapter 19:1, I saw heaven opened and then Christ comes. It's a very important phrase because I think it is used to take us step by step through the chronology of the coming of Christ.

[00:27:00] It is used when the Lord returns. It is then used at the defeat of Antichrist. It is then used to introduce the banishment of Satan at the outset of the kingdom. It is then used at the introduction of the kingdom, the millennial kingdom. It is used to at the opening of the release and the destruction of Satan. It is used to introduce the scene of the great white throne. And it is used to introduce the new heaven and the new earth. It's a technical phrase that

[00:27:30] introduces each of the sequential events from the return of Christ to the establishment of the eternal state. I saw a new heaven and a new earth following the Lord's return, following the defeat of Antichrist, following the banishment of Satan at the beginning of the kingdom, following the kingdom, following the release of Satan and his destruction, following the great white throne comes the new heaven and the new earth. And there you have the sequence, the escatological sequence leading up to the eternal state signaled by the little

[00:28:00] phrase and I saw. What did he see? A new heaven and a new earth. Now this terminology is drawn from the Old Testament. And I just remind you of two scriptures. Isaiah 65:17. For behold, God said through the prophet Isaiah, I create new heavens and a new earth. And so new that the former things shall not be remembered or come to mind.

[00:28:30] Be glad and rejoice forever in what I create. Then in Isaiah 66:22, just as the new heavens and the new earth which I make will endure before me, declares the Lord, so your offspring and your name will endure. And again there twice Isaiah refers to the new heaven and the new earth. And so John is taking that phrase right right from as it were the pin of the prophet.

[00:29:00] What Isaiah had predicted is now a reality in the vision that John is having. So there's coming a new heaven and a new earth. And I say to you what I've said all the way along. The earth we live on is temporary disposable. We're not to preserve it. That's pointless. I'm not saying that you are um indiscriminate in how you care for the resources around you. I'm not saying that you should wantingly pollute the world and make life difficult and things like that. But I am saying the idea of

> [00:29:30] preserving this world runs contrary to the plan of God. It is disposable. It is unraveling. It is declining. It is winding down. The law of entropy which says that matter is always breaking down and tending toward disorder is indeed occurring. And consequently, we are living on a disposable planet. God does not intend for it to remain. The goals of all those who want to save the earth, the save the planet people are really wasting their time because → 'Save the planet people are really wasting their time' — creation-care dismissed; Earth as 'disposable' — the escape strand preached as the whole canon

> [00:30:00] this one will be replaced by an eternal new heaven and new earth. In fact, the earth is not headed for an ecological crisis. I want to take that burden off your back. The earth is not headed for an ecological crisis. It is not headed for an ecological holocaust. It is headed for an escatological holocaust. Now the word new is important. It's not the word nas which means new as opposed → 'Save the planet people are really wasting their time' — creation-care dismissed; Earth as 'disposable' — the escape strand preached as the whole canon

[00:30:30] to old. It's the word kinos which means new in quality. It measures not the timeliness of something being new or that the fact that it is new on the calendar. It is new to this period of time, but simply that it is new in quality. It is fresh. It is different. There's coming a different heaven and earth. Yes, it is new in terms of chronology, but it is the point that the writer is making here is that it is new

[00:31:00] in terms of kind. It's different. The quality of it is completely different from the one we now know. And we won't even have any remembrance of the one that now exists. God originally made the universe and the earth, I believe, to be the permanent home for mankind. And Eden would have been his permanent home and he would have lived forever. Except that men and women sinned in the garden. Sin and death entered in, corrupted the world and the universe. The fall of angels of

[00:31:30] course added to the corruption. The earth became a place that had to be destroyed. Decay entered in. It started unraveling and decaying and ultimately God has to wipe it out. There will come a new heaven. Think about it. A heaven with no more tempests, a heaven with no more storms, no more fierce winds, no more thunder, no more rain, and no more demons and devils roaming. And there will be a new earth with no miseries of godlessness, no longer smarting under the curse.

[00:32:00] An earth whose forever hills will flow with holiness and the river of salvation and whose eternal valleys know only the peace of the paradise of God. This has to happen. There has to be a new heaven and a new earth. Why? Back to verse one. For the first heaven and the first earth passed away. That was described back in chapter 20 11. I saw a great white throne and him who sat upon it from whose presence earth

[00:32:30] and heaven fled away and no place was found for them. At that point we discussed the fact that the universe goes out of existence when God gathers the ungodly at the great white throne and then sends them into the lake of fire. And because the universe is gone, he has to create a new one. The heavens and earth that we now know must be destroyed.

[00:33:00] You remember how the Old Testament prophet said, "The heavens are not pure in his sight." Job 15:15. That was true. Isaiah 24:5, "The earth is polluted." And consequently, the psalmist writing in Psalm 102 wrote, "Of old, thou dst found the earth, and the heavens are the work of thy hands. Even they will perish, but thou dost endure, and all of them will wear out like a garment, like

[00:33:30] clothing. Thou wilt change them, and they will be changed. The old clothing gone, and new garment will come." And by the way, that identical passage is quoted in Hebrews 1:es 10 to 12. Thou, Lord, in the beginning did lay the foundation of the earth, the heavens, the work of thy hands. They will perish but thou remainest. Jesus said in Luke 21, heaven and earth will pass away. So because heaven and earth as we know it, this whole and massive universe will

[00:34:00] be uncreated. And when you think about the creation of it, I mean, think about the creation of a universe where you can go 880 quadrillion miles, reach a star 200 million miles in diameter, and still be in your galaxy. And there are billions more galaxies beyond it. Imagine that massive universe being unccreated and then in its place a new heaven and a new earth.

[00:34:30] You say what's it going to be like? He only gives us one clue. End of verse one. Just this is the only clue. There's no longer any sea. Hm. You say, "Is that a clue?" Yeah. There's no longer any sea. That's all he says. Now, that means it's going to be different because 3/4 of the Earth's surface is covered with what? Water.

[00:35:00] And you know something? I want to announce to you that you're mostly water. Did you know that your blood is 90% water? your flesh is 65% water. Um this then this world in which we live is basically a watery world.

> [00:35:30] There's not only water in the oceans, there's water in the land. And we're water and plants are mostly water and animals are mostly water. And the earth, did you know, is the only place in the known universe where there's water enough to sustain man, plants, and animals? → Throwaway anti-evolution aside

> [00:36:00] Tell me that's evolution. Can't be. The sea is emblematic of a of a waterbased environment. Man's existence is water-based. You die if you get dehydrated. So, what is he saying here? Well, what he's saying is uh the new heaven and the new earth don't operate on water anymore. Now, that's enough to tell you it's → Throwaway anti-evolution aside

[00:36:30] going to be different. No more evaporation, distillation, and condensation. new climatic conditions and whatever we are in our glorified form is not going to depend upon a process that demands consumption of water. The new heaven and the whole new universe isn't going to have to have a whole lot of oceans.

[00:37:00] Won't have to have any. It won't have any. So in our glorified form, no water is needed. You say, "Well, is there going to be any water at all there?" I might get thirsty even there in heaven. Well, you probably won't. But in Revelation 22, it says, "He showed me a river of the water of life." That's the only water. It's It's not the H2O kind. It's the water of what? Life.

[00:37:30] So whatever whatever the water of life is is what gives us life. But it's not the kind of water we know. It's not a chemical called H2O. You say, "Well, why does he say that?" Well, just to point out that it's different. And that's about as profound a way to express its difference from the physical standpoint as any way he could say it. Because if there's no water there, there's no sea there, then life is going to be so completely different than anything we could even understand

[00:38:00] in its glorified form. The eternal state is totally different. So verse one, the appearance of the new heaven and the new earth. And I can't tell you any more than that, folks, because that's all there is there. We will be literally raised. We will be literally given resurrection bodies. We will dwell in an eternally new heaven and earth that will be based on a completely different life principle than what we know now in this created universe.

[00:38:30] Now let's move to the second point. He starts out with the appearance of the new heaven and the new earth and then secondly the capital of the new heaven and new earth. the capital. Verse two, and I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, made ready as a bride adorned for her husband. Now, here we are introduced to the capital city of heaven, which is the New Jerusalem. Now, you want to mark something in your own mind. The new Jerusalem isn't all there is to heaven.

[00:39:00] Because later on in the chapter, we're going to find out just exactly how large the New Jerusalem is. It is even measured out down there in verse 16 as 1,500 miles cubed. But you've got a whole new heaven and new earth, a whole new created realm that is vast, that is infinite, that is eternal. And in the middle of it, you have a capital city called the New Jerusalem that is 1500 miles cubed.

[00:39:30] You say, "Are you sure this is literal?" Well, if it isn't, I haven't got any idea what he's talking about. Because if you ask me to accept this as something that's not literal, then how am I going to know what it is? You read commentators who say, "Well, he doesn't really mean a real city." Well, what does he mean? Says city. And who is going to unravel the mystery of what he means when he doesn't say what he means? Says here, "There was a holy city called New Jerusalem coming down out of heaven

[00:40:00] from God." So, you know what I conclude? There was a holy city called the new Jerusalem coming down out of heaven from God. And that's what John saw. Notice the the holy city, new Jerusalem. There are three Jerusalems really in redemptive history. There's the old city of Jerusalem, the historic Jerusalem, the old city of David. the Jebusites

[00:40:30] once occupied in the land of Palestine, that city that still exists today and can be visited. People live there. There is that city, that old city of Jerusalem, that um historic city. And by the way, even as the historic Jerusalem, it is called the holy city. That's right. It is referred to in the Old Testament Isaiah 52:1, Nehemiah 11:1,

[00:41:00] Daniel 9:24. It is referred to in the New Testament, Matthew 4:5, Matthew 27:53, Revelation 11:2. It is referred to the historic city as the holy city. What that means is not that everybody in it is holy, but that it was set apart unto God. It was set apart for divine purposes. It was to be devoted to God. But it's it's not that everybody in it was holy or is holy or will be holy.

[00:41:30] Eventually, it'll become the seat of Antichrist's desecration and the raising of false worship of him. So, it's holy in the sense that God set it apart for divine purposes, but obviously nothing beyond that. The millennial Jerusalem, which will come during the thousand-year period, will be holy as well because Christ will sit on the throne of David in the city of Jerusalem, rule with a rod of iron. And so, there will be a greater holiness

[00:42:00] to that city as Christ, the holy one, reigns there and maintains order through swift judgment. But this is not the historic old Jerusalem and this is not the millennial Jerusalem. This is the eternal city. It is called the holy city, new Jerusalem. And this is holy not because it is set apart to God. Not because Christ is there, but it is

[00:42:30] holy now because every person in it is perfectly holy. And so Jerusalem will have gone from a a holiness by virtue of being devoted to God to a holiness by virtue of being ruled by Christ to a holiness by virtue of being occupied only by holy people. Everyone in it will be perfectly holy.

> [00:43:00] Chapter 20 verse 6 of Revelation. Blessed and holy is the one who has part in the first resurrection that takes people to heaven. Now, it's hard to imagine a holy city, isn't it? Certainly, Los Angeles wouldn't qualify the world's cities. In fact, just the opposite of being holy of all of human society, the most unholy is in the cities, isn't it? The world's cities are pockets of → Cities as uniformly wicked — against Jesus's urban lament

> [00:43:30] wickedness, pockets of unholy living and unholy thinking. The world's cities are the the real symbol of decay and decadence and immorality and crime, pollution. The world cities are a swamp of sin and iniquity, corruption, graft, thievery. From New York to Tokyo, from Los Angeles to Moscow, from Rio to Paris, we don't know anything about a holy → Cities as uniformly wicked — against Jesus's urban lament

[00:44:00] city. But this city is the holy city. The sinless capital city of eternity where everybody who lives in it is perfectly holy. The idea of a city talks about relationships and activity. It talks about responsibility, unity, socialization, harmony, communion, living together, doing things, cooperating. And I think uh the Lord is showing us it'll have everything that a city has in

[00:44:30] terms of people living together and working together and serving together. And the difference will be they will all be godly. In Revelation 3:12, this city was first mentioned in the book of Revelation. And the name of the city of my God, the new Jerusalem, which comes down out of heaven from God. And he says it's promised to those who are overcomers. But there is the same description. It is the city called New Jerusalem coming down out of heaven from

[00:45:00] God. Hebrews uh talks about this. Do you remember Hebrews chapter 11? It says that Abraham was looking for the city which has foundations, whose architect and builder is God. What do you think he was looking for? He was living for what? For heaven. in chapter 12 of uh Hebrews verse 22 you have come to Mount Zion to the city of

[00:45:30] the living God the heavenly Jerusalem where there are myriads of angels and the general assembly and church of the firstborn are enrolled in heaven and God is there the judge of all and the spirits of righteous men made perfect are there and Jesus is there that's all in Hebrews 12:22- 24 this heavenly Jerusalem where the angels are and the saints are and God is and Jesus is.

[00:46:00] That's the new Jerusalem. Abraham looked for that city and one day went there. And all of the saints that have died are gone are gone there now. And they're there in their spirits. It's that city. I think the best way to understand this beloved is that anybody who dies, any saint who dies goes to the heavenly Jerusalem.

[00:46:30] That heaven is the heavenly Jerusalem. In fact, we could say that all heaven is contained currently in the heavenly Jerusalem because the universe as it exists is

touched and stained by sin. So until there is created a new heaven and a new earth, heaven doesn't fill all of infinity.

[00:47:00] To put it another way, think of John 14. And I think this will begin to pull some things together in your mind. I know it does in mine. In John 14, Jesus, of course, was telling his disciples he was going to leave. And you remember the little talk he had, let not your heart be troubled. Believe in God, believe in me. In my father's house, what's that? Well, my father has a house. And in that house are many rooms. I'm going get your room ready,

[00:47:30] and then I'm going to come and get you and take you there. I believe Jesus left the earth, went back to the heavenly Jerusalem, the city who's who has the city that has a foundation, whose builder and maker is God. He went back to the heavenly Jerusalem where there are just men whose spirits are there and the angels are there and God is there and of course Christ is there. and he went back there

[00:48:00] to prepare a place for us. And someday he's going to bring us to that place. It's important then to see that the new Jerusalem exists even now in some form. It's really heaven. It's where God is. And when a believer dies, they go to the place the Lord has for them. But someday when God creates a whole new infinite

[00:48:30] universe, that heaven, that third heaven, that father's house, that new Jerusalem, that city whose builder and maker is God is going to come down and descend into the midst of the new universe. And it will be the home of all the godly. It'll be where we dwell because we're not you're not saying I'm living on Pluto and you're living over on Saturn

[00:49:00] and somebody else is living over in some galaxy somewhere. We're all in the father's what? House. And so we'll all live in the city. We can just go anywhere we want. But home will be the new Jerusalem. All the glorified of all the ages will live in that city because they'll all live in the father's house where Jesus has gone. And if he's gone now, listen carefully. If he's gone there now to prepare a place now, it has to be being

[00:49:30] prepared in a place that now exists. And the new heaven and the new earth don't now exist. You understand what I'm saying? That's why the scripture is so clear that the time is going to come in the end when God creates a new heaven and a new earth, a whole new universe and down from him into that new universe will descend the heavenly city

[00:50:00] coming down from God out of heaven. In fact, in chapter 21, look down to verse 10. He carried me away in the spirit to a great and high mountain and showed me the holy city, Jerusalem, coming down Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God. That's a third time it says that back in chapter 3 and here twice that this comes down. It it

indicates to me that it doesn't come into existence. It just descends from God into the new heaven and the new earth. That's just a

[00:50:30] technicality, but I think it shows you the explicit nature of the description here. The Lord is now preparing a place for us in the father's house. The father's house is in the heavenly Jerusalem or heaven as we know it. And someday the whole thing will descend into the eternal state, the new universe. It is from God. What does that mean? It's a God kind of city. It's a God designed and God made city. He's the architect and he's the builder

[00:51:00] and it bears all the marks of his holy glory. And I'm telling you, when we get down into verse 9 and go through the rest of the description here, you'll see what that means. So, the heavenly city will have already been prepared. Jesus is preparing it now. And when he comes for his own, he's going to take his own into that place. And when the rapture of the church occurs, we'll go to that place he's preparing for us. And that'll be our home. And we'll dwell

[00:51:30] there even during the time of the millennium. We'll go back and forth into the earth in glorified form and back to that holy city. And then finally, the holy city will become the capital city of eternity. In further describing the capital city, John says in verse two, it was made ready as a bride adorned for her husband. He borrows this magnificent imagery of a

[00:52:00] wedding. Now in Jewish terms, there were three parts to a wedding. First was betroal. And what happened? That's like an engagement only it was real serious. Families got together and they pledged the two young people to one another and it was a binding contract and it was signed and it was settled. There was a period when the the couple did not come together physically at all during the betroal but was followed by a a period or an

[00:52:30] event called the presentation. Presentation was when the bride was brought out and presented the groom was brought out and there was usually a week of feasting. The end of the week there was the ceremony. So you had the betroal, the presentation, the ceremony and after the ceremony was over you had the consummation. It is that magnificent imagery that you see here. The betroal took place in eternity past when God wrote the names of his own

> [00:53:00] beloved in the lamb's book of life from before the foundation of the world. The betroal took place in eternity past when God the father pledged to give to the son a redeemed humanity that he would choose. The presentation, the presentation occurred at the rapture of the church when the bride was taken to be with the bridegroom. And for seven years, there would be a wonderful feasting. → New Jerusalem read only as destination, not as pattern for the church's life now

> [00:53:30] The end of that period, the ceremony takes place. You could liken the ceremony to the millennial kingdom, the great celebration, the final great feast as the bride and the groom are joined together. Then it's followed by the consummation which would be like the eternal state. So he says, I saw the new Jerusalem coming down and it's it's made ready as a bride → New Jerusalem read only as destination, not as pattern for the church's life now

[00:54:00] adorned for her husband. It's time for the consummation. Why does he describe the city that way? Because the city contained the bride. And so he sees it as the bride city. You know, in the very beginning of God's redemptive plan, you know what his purpose was? To go get a bride for his son, wasn't it? It was to go get a bride for his son. And he did.

[00:54:30] And by the time you come to this point in the chronology of Revelation, the the bride is collected. All the Old Testament saints are incorporated into the final figure of the bride. All the tribulation saints are incorporated in it. All of those who were converted during the time of the kingdom. All of the church is is included. And they're all in the bridal city. They're all encompassed in the bride that God has chosen for his son. And the city descends with all the redeemed in it into the eternal state.

[00:55:00] Back in chapter 19, just briefly, verse 7, let us rejoice and be glad and give glory to him, for the marriage of the Lamb has come and his bride has made herself ready. And it was given to her to clothe herself in fine linen, bright and clean, for the fine linen is the righteous acts of the saints. And he said to me, "Write, blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb." And he said to me, these are the true words of God. When you're studying that in chapter 19, you realize that not everybody who's at that feast, that initial celebration, is part of the bride because it says, "Blessed are

[00:55:30] those invited." So, you've got a bride and some invited guests. So, we we when we studied that, we pointed out very clearly that the bride is the church. The bride is the church. And the picture of Christ being joined to his bride is the picture of Christ being joined to his glorified church. The church is the pure, faithful bride, never a harlot like Israel. The church is the bride during the during the presentation feast in heaven after the rapture.

[00:56:00] But then when the church comes down to earth when Jesus returns and sets up his kingdom, you come to the full final ceremony of the wedding. I believe then all the saints are collected and gathered in and so the bride becomes all-encompassing and so does the bride become all-encompassing in the eternal state. So here is the consummation all things resolved in Christ. All things resolved in the father and that's

[00:56:30] what Paul points out in 1 Corinthians 15 where he says all things are subjected to him. Verse 28, the son himself will be subjected to the one who subjected all things to him that God may be all in all. At the at the final great event of the ceremony during the kingdom followed by the consummation, all the saints of all the ages of all the ages can be brought into the bride metaphor so that it encompasses all of them. So John then sees the capital city and

[00:57:00] it is adorned as a bride because it contains all the redeemed of all the ages who ultimately are the bride that the father has sought to give to his son. Marvelous. And the new Jerusalem is a bridal city. The old historic Jerusalem back in 11:8 was called Sodom and Egypt because it was so rotten and so wretched. The millennial kingdom didn't reach this level of perfection either. And the millennial Jerusalem was besieged by a

[00:57:30] satanic rebellion according to chapter 20:3 and following. So we're dealing here with a new Jerusalem. This is the holy new Jerusalem. More gloriously wonderful than the present Jerusalem as Paul calls it in Galatians 4 or the millennial Jerusalem. So as we look at heaven then through the eyes of John in his vision we see the appearance of the new heaven and the new earth and the capital city. Then one last point

[00:58:00] we see the supreme personality of the new heaven and the new earth. The supreme personality. And I'm only going to say something brief about this because there's so much to say I want to keep it for next time. Look at verse three. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "Behold, the tabernacle of God is among men, and he shall dwell among them, and they

[00:58:30] shall be his people, and God himself shall be among them." Who is the supreme person of heaven? Who is it? It's God. Whom have I in heaven but thee? Psalm 73:25. And who do I desire on earth but thee? I heard a loud voice from the throne. That's about 20 times plus that that phrase has appeared. That a loud voice has come out of the throne. Probably some angelic announcer. And the

[00:59:00] announcement is behold the tabernacle of God is among men. God no longer is a far off, no longer in a different place. Tabernacle is ske the place of abode. the place where you live. This is the father's house. In the new Jerusalem is the father's house and the father's house is among

[00:59:30] his own. Jesus went away to prepare a place for us in the father's house so that the father could come and live in his house with all of us. Behold, amazing God is living in the same house with men. It's an absolutely unthinkable reality to a Jew who wouldn't even say the name of God because of fearful reverence. And yet a Jew should remember Leviticus

[01:00:00] 26:11 and 12 says, "I will make my dwelling among you. I will also walk among you and be your God, and you shall be my people." And though that had historic import and historic significance, that is nothing compared to its eternal significance. The Emmanuel, God with us is really with us. Not just in human flesh, in the form of Jesus Christ, but now Emmanuel is with us in all his fullness. No more

[01:00:30] veiled in flesh. No more in a holy of holies in a tabernacle or a temple. No more in a pillar by day or a cloud a cloud by day or a pillar of fire by night. No more is God transcendent. God comes and makes his home with us. Now this is the father's house and we're all in it together. That is the amazing reality of heaven. Blessed are the pure in heart for they shall see God. That means according to verse 22 of this

[01:01:00] chapter, look at it. There's no temple. John sees a new Jerusalem and there's no temple. Why? Because the Lord God, the Almighty, and the Lamb are the temple. In other words, a temple would indicate that you have to go somewhere to see God or go somewhere as in the Old Testament to behold the shikina. You don't need a temple because you're in God's house. This is so staggering that John's listening to this voice and the voice

[01:01:30] repeats this thing several times. The tabernacle of God is among men. And then the voice says it another way. And he shall dwell among them. God's going to dwell with his own. And what the psalmist anticipated when he said, "In thy presence is fullness of joy. At thy right hand are pleasures forever." is going to become reality. When it says dwell, it's the same root as the word tabernacle and it's related

[01:02:00] to the term for shikina, the very presence of God. Shikina means habitation. Deuteronomy 12:5. He says it another way. First, he says, "The tabernacle of God is among men." Then he says, "He shall dwell among them." And then he says, "And they shall be his people." It's it's almost as if this thing is so mindboggling he has to keep repeating himself. God himself shall be among them. If he had just said he shall dwell among them,

[01:02:30] they might say, "Well, yes, uh in his glory and and perhaps in a veiled way because he's so great." And when he said, "And they shall be his he shall be among them." Well, yes. Yes, he's going to move in their midst. Yes, we understand that. And

then he says, "And they shall be his people." Personal possession. Personal possession. And then, as if that's not enough, he adds again, "And God himself shall be

[01:03:00] among them." Haven't we already heard that God himself is the addition? God is among men. He dwells among them. They are his people. Yes, you heard me right. God himself Wow. God appeared in the theophanes of the patriarchal time. God spoke to the prophets audibly and personally. God led his people by day and by night with his presence. God showed them his glory. God

[01:03:30] came certainly in the flesh of Jesus Christ. And we beheld his glory. The glory is of the only begotten full of grace and truth. Evidently God who was transfigured before them. In Matthew's gospel 17, it tells about it. God has come to believers in the form of the indwelling Holy Spirit. God has come in the form of the reigning Messiah, Jesus Christ, in the millennial kingdom. But this is God's presence like no other occasion. And this then is the supreme personality

[01:04:00] of heaven. We want to be there because God is there. Whom have I in heaven but thee? Who do I care about up there but you? You're the supreme one. 1 Thessalonians 4 says when the church is raptured, we will ever be with the Lord. That is the issue. We will ever be with the Lord. It is being with God that

[01:04:30] makes heaven heaven. Father, Jesus prayed in John 17:24, I desire that they also whom thou hast given me be with me where I am. I want them with me where I am. What a prayer. And it is answered. No intercessors, no mediators, absolute communion with God, no fear, no restraint because there's no sin. Eager approach to his holy presence at

[01:05:00] all times. will be really in the presence of God. That is incredible, marvelous, unimaginable, but that is the promise of heaven. Next Sunday night is going to be communion. But I'm going to spend the preparation for communion finishing what I said tonight and showing you what is

[01:05:30] going to happen when we are in the presence of God in heaven. Father, thank you for this great hope. Thank you for what you have laid before us. Oh, Father, how awesome it all is. And Lord, we do pray that you would cause us to set our affections on things above and not on things on the earth.

[01:06:00] We sap so much strength, so much energy, and so many resources fussing about the trivialities of this life instead of investing our energies and our thoughts in that which is eternal. Thank you for the hope of heaven which enables us to endure anything here in the light of what is to come. Thank you for the hope of heaven which is the greatest incentive to excellence

[01:06:30] in our Christian character which is the truest truest path to joy which is the best defense against sin. Thank you for the hope of heaven which strengthens our spiritual service and causes us to honor you. Help us to live in the light of the glory to come to treat very lightly this world for there is a far more eternal weight of glory.

[01:07:00] May we hold lightly to the passing things and feel the true weight of what is eternal. And should there be anyone in our midst, Lord, anyone who hears this message that is not on the way to heaven, we pray that you would save them by your grace and turn their course from a course to destruction to a path to glory for Jesus' sake. Amen.

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Methodology

Axis 1 — Fidelity to Jesus's Teachings: findings flag contradictions with, tensions against, or notable absences from Jesus's direct words in the four Gospels. Reference translation: ESV.

Axis 2 — Identifiable Biases / Harmful Rhetoric: co-equal sub-rubrics for Christian nationalism (Whitehead & Perry's *Taking America Back for God*; Du Mez, *Jesus and John Wayne*; Alberta, *The Kingdom, the Power, and the Glory*), anti-Muslim framing, anti-LGBTQ framing, misogynistic framing, and anti-Jewish framing. Findings weighted by *reach × specificity × real-world harm potential*.

Axis 3 — Factual Claims & Evidence Check: empirical claims extracted from the sermon are compared against independent scholarly, journalistic, and primary sources. Each claim receives a verdict (Supported · Partially supported · Contested · Misleading · Unsupported · False) and records whether the pastor cited evidence when making the claim (a rhetorical concern distinct from the empirical verdict). No verdict is rendered without a cited source.

Axis 4 — Whole-Bible Engagement: for each major framing in the sermon, the pastor's claim is placed side-by-side with Jesus's Gospel witness and with the wider biblical canon (OT and non-Gospel NT). This surfaces cherry-picking (citing a favorable verse while ignoring hostile ones on the same topic) and unacknowledged canonical tension (presenting one biblical voice as the biblical position when the scripture itself contains disagreement). Gospel citations are in ESV; OT and non-Gospel NT citations are in ESV.

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